Great Game thinking dictated that Russia, in whatever form, was the avowed enemy of Britain in South Asia. And yet, as the Indian government would consistently argue, when pan-Islamism combined with Asian nationalism it proved a force more potent than Soviet Russia.[46]

When it came to it, the picture on the potential of Bolshevik Russia to be a threat to Britain in southern Asia was somewhat mixed. On the one hand, there were the reports by Cox and news from Malleson in Meshed that consistently noted the possibility of Bolshevism taking hold in Central Asia.[47] A Tashkent Soviet had seized power in September 1917 and in April 1918 had established the first Soviet republic outside of Russia itself – a potentially worrying occurrence for Britain.[48] And yet an uprising by Orenburg Cossacks had left the Tashkent regime completely cut off from Moscow (and they would remain so until September 1919). To the west an anti-Bolshevik regime in Ashkhabad, supported by Malleson, also separated the Tashkent Soviet from the Caspian route of communication, while in the north-east more hostile Cossacks meant that this revolutionary enclave was completed surrounded.[49]

The presence of British and anti-Bolshevik forces in and around Persia also meant that the new Soviet envoy to Tehran, Karl Bravin, was isolated from his Bolshevik masters. Bravin had been the Russian consul in Khoi in Persian Azerbaijan and arrived in Tehran in January 1918.[50] However, the new Bolshevik representative had no credentials from the Soviet regime and although the Persian government had initially been inclined to recognise him, it was soon persuaded to simply ignore Bravin.[51] As he told his superiors, ‘in spite of all our expressions of friendship and our cordial demeanour [the Persian government] are obviously laughing at us’.[52] Without the recognition of the Persian government, Bravin was unable to remove the sitting Russian legation, nor did he have access to any funds. Dejected and unable to do any work of substance, in June 1918 Bravin begged his superiors in Moscow ‘either to give me speedy assistance or to release me from such an unprofitable engagement’.[53]

Just why the Bolshevik regime gave Bravin such little help in his endeavours is likely due to a number of reasons. For one thing, until the Red Army was able to make progress in the south of Russia, Persia was